



## Command Structures

TOPIC LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Upon successful completion of this topic, the student will be able to:
1. Identify the impact of the Goldwater-Nichols DoD Reorganization Act on the chains of command within DoD.
  2. Recognize the major components of the DoD and DoN.
  3. Identify the reporting chain of command (operational or administrative) for various DoD/DoN organizations and individuals.
  4. Identify the Secretary of the Navy’s principal advisors and assistants by title and responsibilities.
  5. Recognize the definitions of common Navy terminology and acronyms (PEO, DRPM, OPNAV, and echelon).
  6. Identify the CNO’s principal advisors and assistants by title and responsibilities.
  7. Identify the mission of COMUSFLTFORCOM.
  8. Recognize the difference between Type Commanders and Numbered Fleet Commanders.
  9. Recognize the relationship of the TYCOMS, Providers, and Resource Sponsors to the Warfare Enterprises.
  10. Identify EDO Flag billets by name and responsibility.

STUDENT PREPARATION

- Student Support Material
1. None
- Primary References
1. Goldwater–Nichols Department of Defense Reorganization Act of 1986 Pub.L. 99–433
  2. [National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 2026](#)
  3. [2026 National Defense Strategy \(NDS\)](#)
- Additional References
1. SECNAVINST 5400.15D: DoN Research and Development, Acquisition, Associated Life-Cycle Management, and Sustainment Responsibilities and Accountability
  2. OPNAVINST 5450.352A:CNO Mission, Functions, Tasks
  3. Web Pages:
    - A. Department of War: <https://www.war.gov>
    - B. Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS): <https://www.jcs.mil/>
    - C. US Navy: <https://www.navy.mil>
    - D. <https://www.war.gov/Experience/Military-Units/Navy/#1309>
    - E. <https://www.secnav.navy.mil/rda/Pages/ASNRD AOrgChart.aspx>



# Overview

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- History of Goldwater-Nichols
- Major DoD/DoN components and reporting chains
  - Admin and Operational
- Deeper dive into DoN
  - SECNAV, CNO, ASN(RD&A), USFFC
- What is an “Enterprise”
- Key people
  - Engineering Duty Admirals



# U.S. Government

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- Constitution establishes three branches of Government
  - Article 1: Legislative Branch (Congress)
    - Section 8: Powers of Congress
      - To provide and maintain a Navy
      - Declare war
  - Article 2: Executive Branch (President)
    - Section 2: Civilian control over the military
  - Article 3: Judicial (Courts)



# Before Goldwater-Nichols

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- World War II and even earlier
  - Secretary of the Navy, Secretary of War, Service Chiefs, Fleet Commanders and Army Commanders
    - Dual roles: Force Provider and Force Commander
- National Security Act of 1947. Established National Military Establishment
  - Established the SECDEF, Central Intelligence Agency, National Security Council, US Air Force
  - War Department became Department of the Air Force and Department of the Army
  - Made the Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS) a 'formal' body with the Chairman (as an official title)
- National Military Establishment renamed Department of Defense in 1949



# Goldwater-Nichols DoD Reorganization Act of 1986

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- Changes
  - Primary: Improve the ability of the Armed Services to conduct Joint operations
  - Secondary: Improve DoD Budget and Acquisition processes
- Why
  - Inter-Service rivalries
    - In combat (Vietnam, Iranian hostage rescue, Grenada)
    - In acquisition
    - In the development of war fighting doctrine
  - Officers did not know very much about the other services



# Goldwater-Nichols DoD Reorganization Act of 1986 (cont.)

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- Three big pieces of the Act
  - Increased the responsibilities of the Chairman JCS
    - Principal military advisor to the President, SECDEF, National Security Council
  - Increase the authority of the Combatant Commands
    - OPCON: President to SECDEF to Combatant Commands
    - ADCON: Service Department Secretaries 'Man, Train, Equip' forces for Combatant Commanders
  - Instituted and established Jointness
    - In the budget process, Officer Training (JPME), Alignment of Program Executive Offices (PEO) to Service Acquisition Executive





# Overview

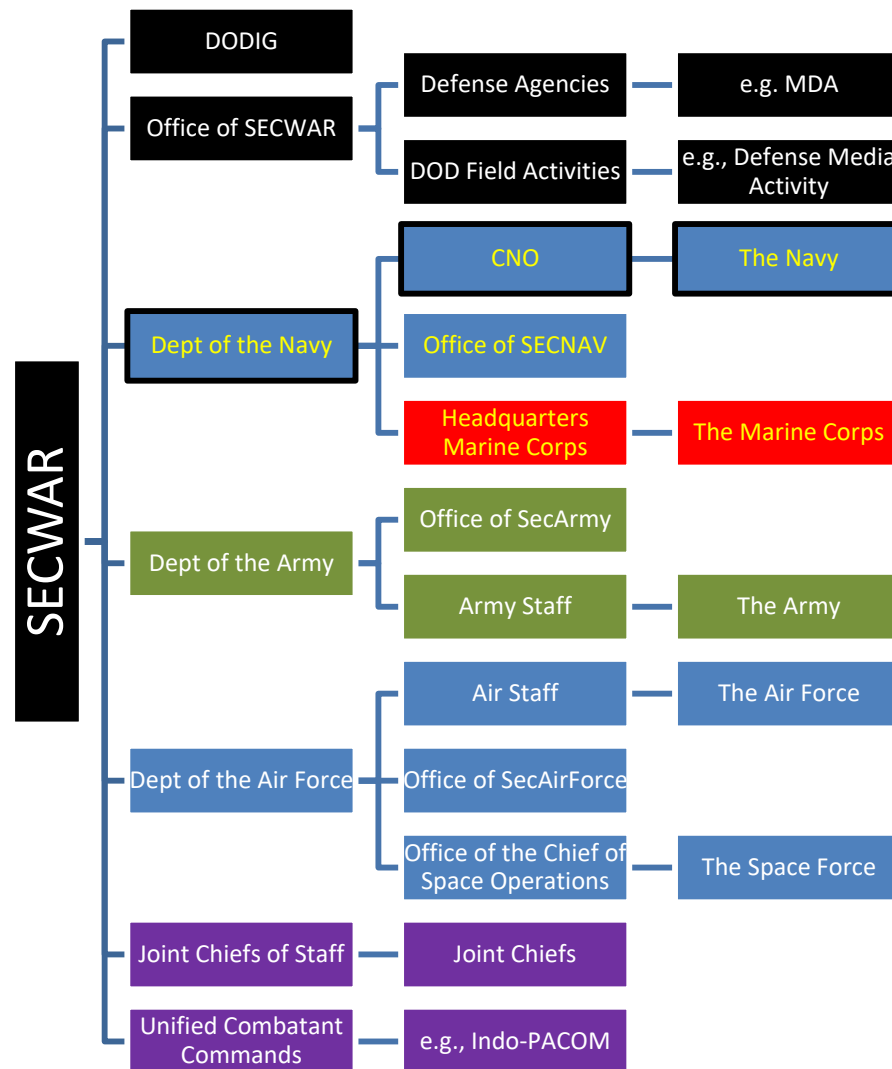
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# DoW and DoN





# Major Components: DoW and DoN

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- Department of War (SECWAR)
  - SECWAR/DEPSECWAR/OSD Staff
  - Joint Staff
  - Service Departments (Service Secretaries)
    - Army
    - Navy/Marine Corps
    - Air Force/Space Force
  - Unified Combatant Commands
- Department of the Navy
  - SECNAV/Principal Advisors (the Secretariat)/Staff
  - CNO and OPNAV Staff
  - Shore Establishment (e.g., Systems Commands (SYSCOMs))
  - Operating Forces



# 2025 National Security Strategy (NSS)

## National Security Strategy

*of the United States of America*

November 2025



NSS

**America First Foreign Policy**: Prioritizes homeland security, replacing global commitments with a transactional, interest-based approach

**Economic Nationalism**: Protects U.S. industry with tariffs while seeking energy dominance through fossil fuel deregulation and ending renewable subsidies

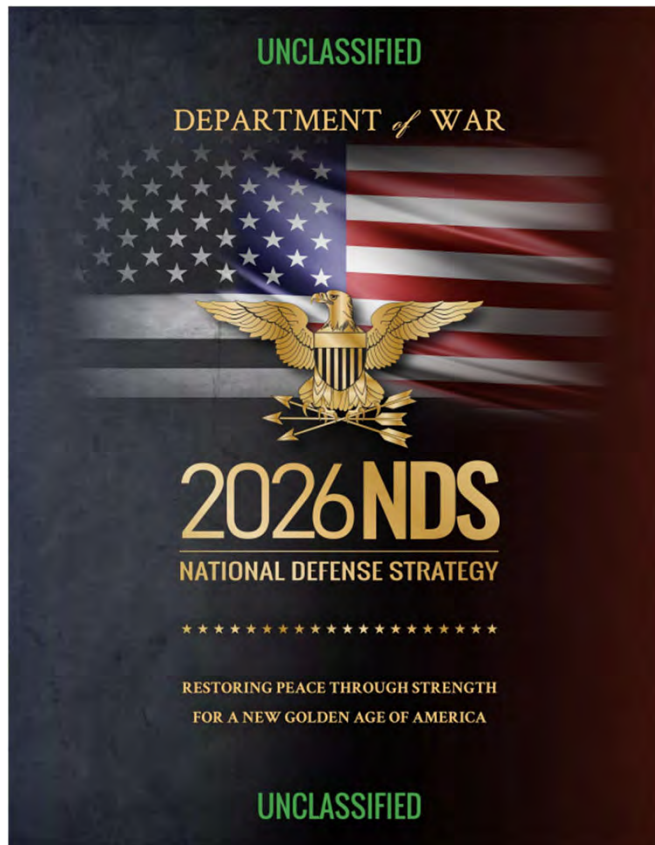
**Confronting Adversaries**: Identifies China as the primary long-term threat and confronts the growing alignment of China, Russia, Iran, and North Korea

**Reassessing Alliances**: Demands allies increase defense spending and align with U.S. interests, putting traditional commitments like NATO under review

**Military Modernization**: Focuses military resources on deterring and preparing for a great power conflict, specifically with China



# 2026 National Defense Strategy



2026 NDS

- **Strategic Approach: key lines of effort**
  1. Defend the U.S. Homeland
  2. Deter China in the Indo-Pacific Through Strength, Not Confrontation
  3. Increase Burden-Sharing with U.S. Allies and Partners
  4. Supercharge the U.S. Defense Industrial Base
- **3 ways to advance the priorities**
  1. Integrated deterrence
  2. Campaigning
  3. Building of an enduring advantage

America First. Peace Through Strength. Common Sense.



# SECNAV: One Navy-Marine Corps Team



**Mission:** DoN will recruit, train, and organize to deliver combat ready naval forces to deter and, if necessary, win conflicts and wars through sustained forward naval presence in support of the joint force

## Strengthening Maritime Dominance

- Industrial Base
- Climate
- Uncrewed Technology
- Rearm, Refuel, Repair, Revive, Resupply

## Building a Culture of Warfighting Excellence

- Taking Care of People
- Education
- Research, Development, Science, and Technology

## Enhancing Strategic Partnerships

- Naval Diplomacy
- Defense Ecosystem
- Congress
- National Call to Service





# Assistant Secretary of the Navy, Research, Development and Acquisition (ASN(RD&A)) Guidance

## ■ Focus Areas

- Open Systems/DevSecOps/Cyber resilient systems/AI/ML
- Focused on improving how we are advancing the art of acquisition
- Business model is PEO/PM primary job.
  - How we are leveraging Industry, Labs, UARCs
  - Work smarter not harder

## ■ Key Stakeholders

- DoN workforce
- American public
- Industrial partners and academia
- Congress
- International partners
- DoW and interagency partners

## ASN (RDA)



Jason L. Potter  
Performing Duties of ASN(RDA)

- Provide improved readiness and cutting-edge capabilities to the warfighter to ensure the balance of power in strategic competition remains in our favor
- Advance nuclear modernization to sustain a strategic deterrent that is safe, secure, and effective
- Develop the next generation of scientists and engineers to advance an international order that is conducive to collective security and prosperity
- Remain a force multiplier for US security around the world by providing allies and partners with Foreign Military Sales and international security cooperation



# Chains of Command

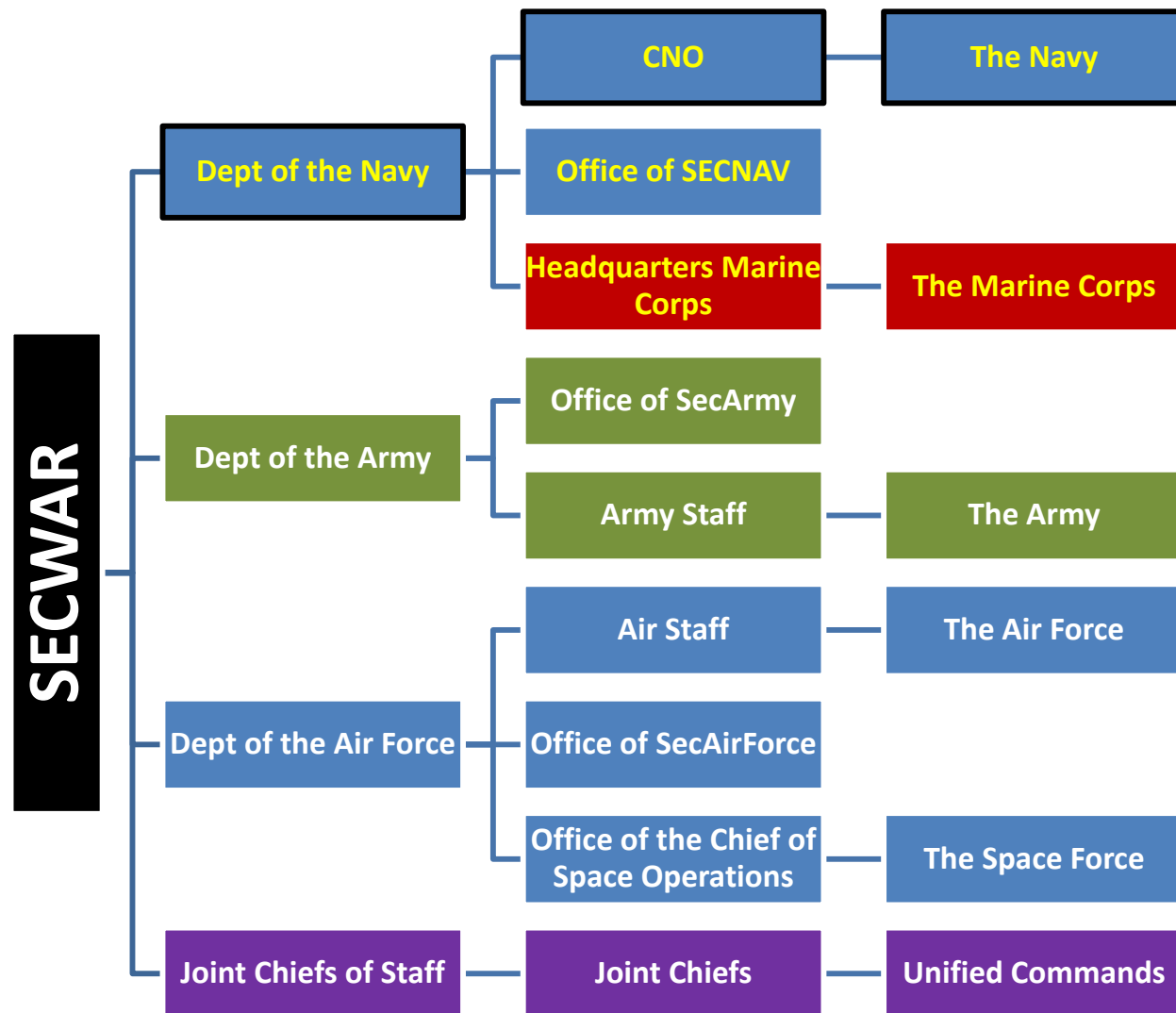
- Administrative - ADCON
  - Provides authority over subordinate commands with respect to administration and support **“man, train, and equip”**
- Operational - OPCON
  - Provides authority over subordinate commands with respect to operations **“combat forces - fighting wars”**
  - DoW Example: SECWAR passes operational orders to Central Command

*An explanation of the Operational & Administrative Chains of Command*  
<https://www.war.gov/Experience/Military-Units/Navy/#1309>



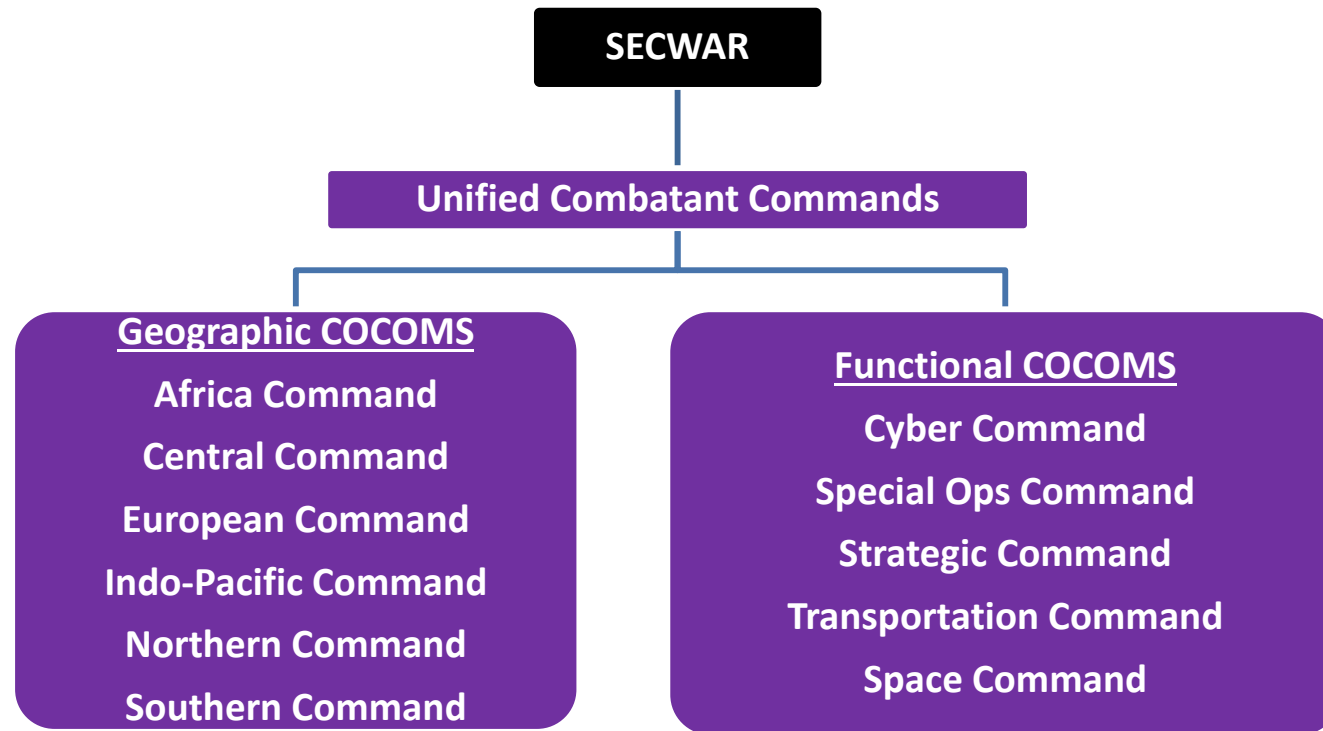


# Administrative Chain of Command





# Operational Chain of Command



2.1.1 Command Structures



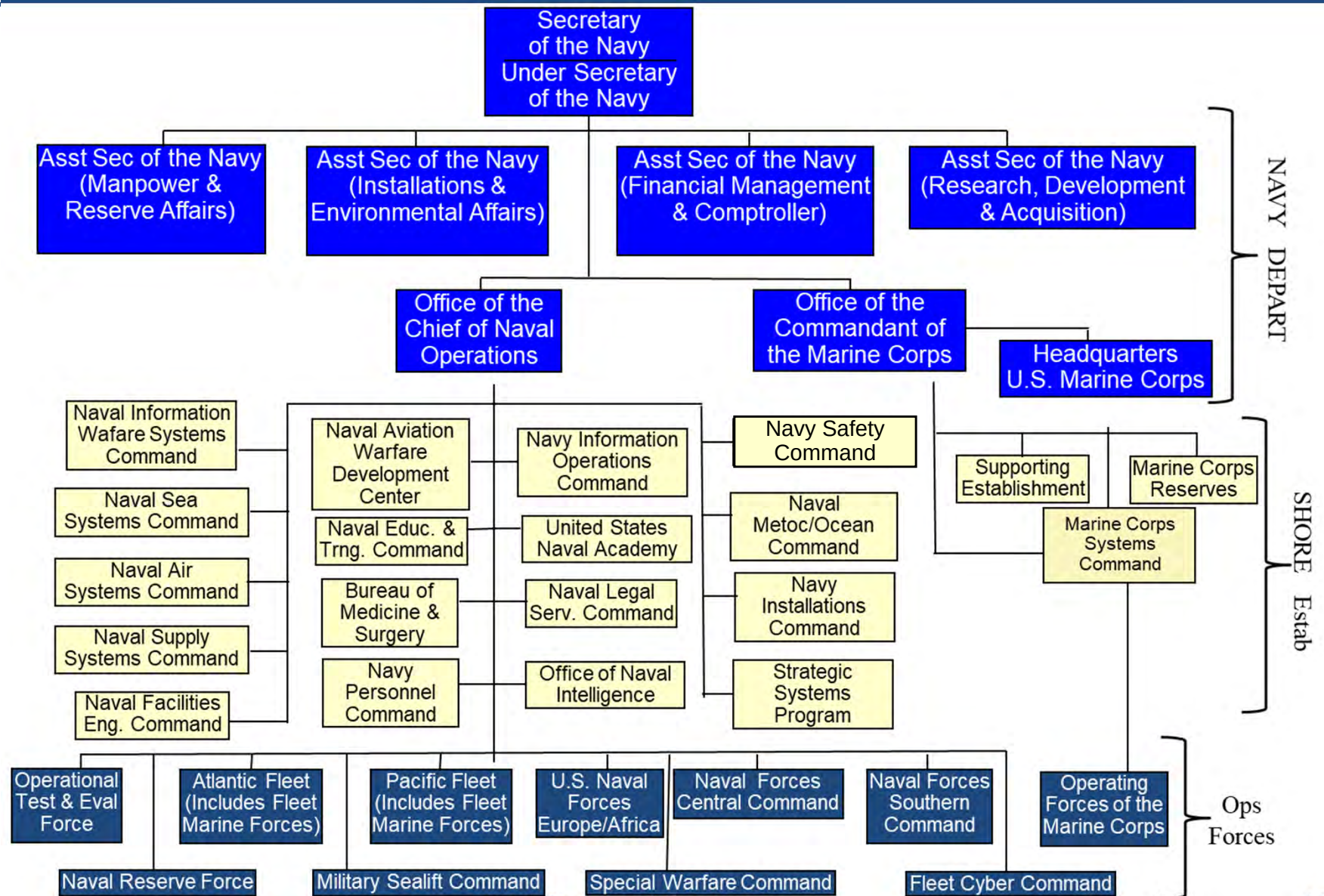
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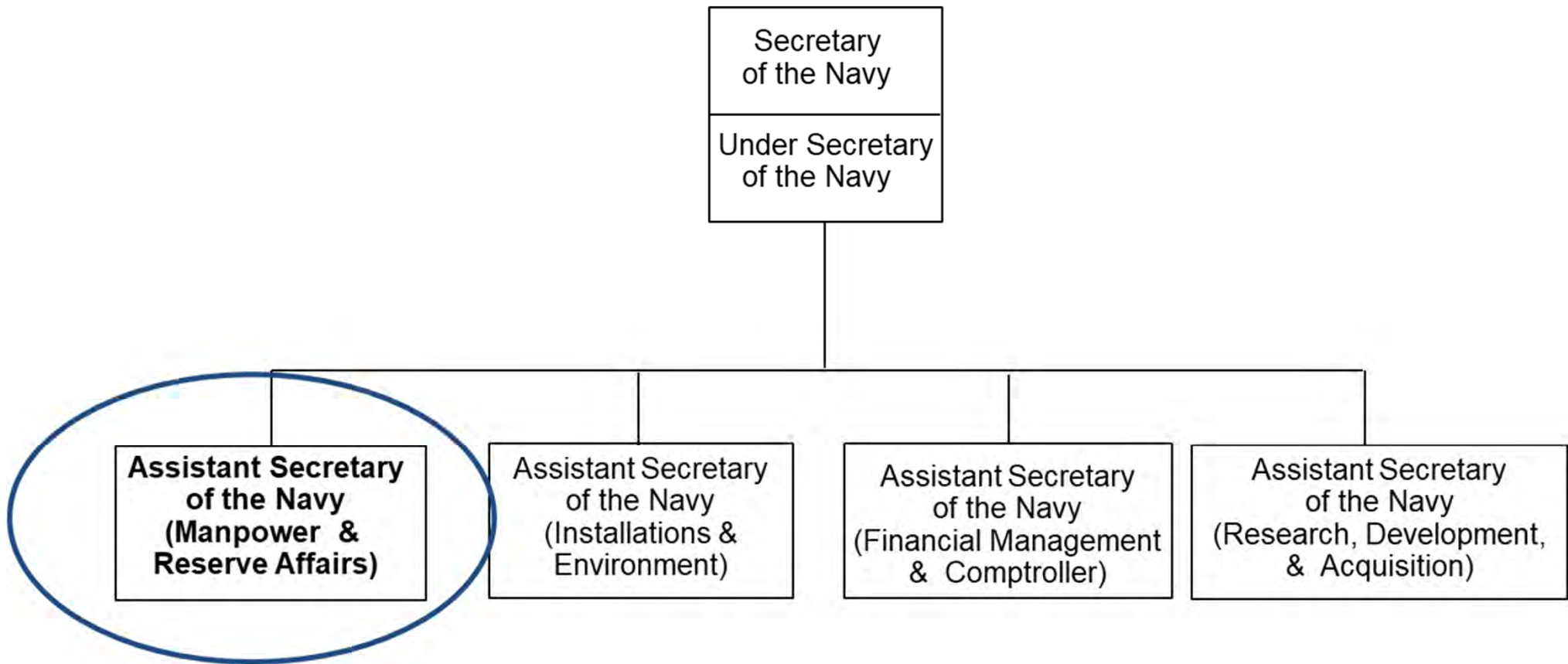
# Department of the Navy



2.1.1 Command Structures



# SECNAV Principal Advisors

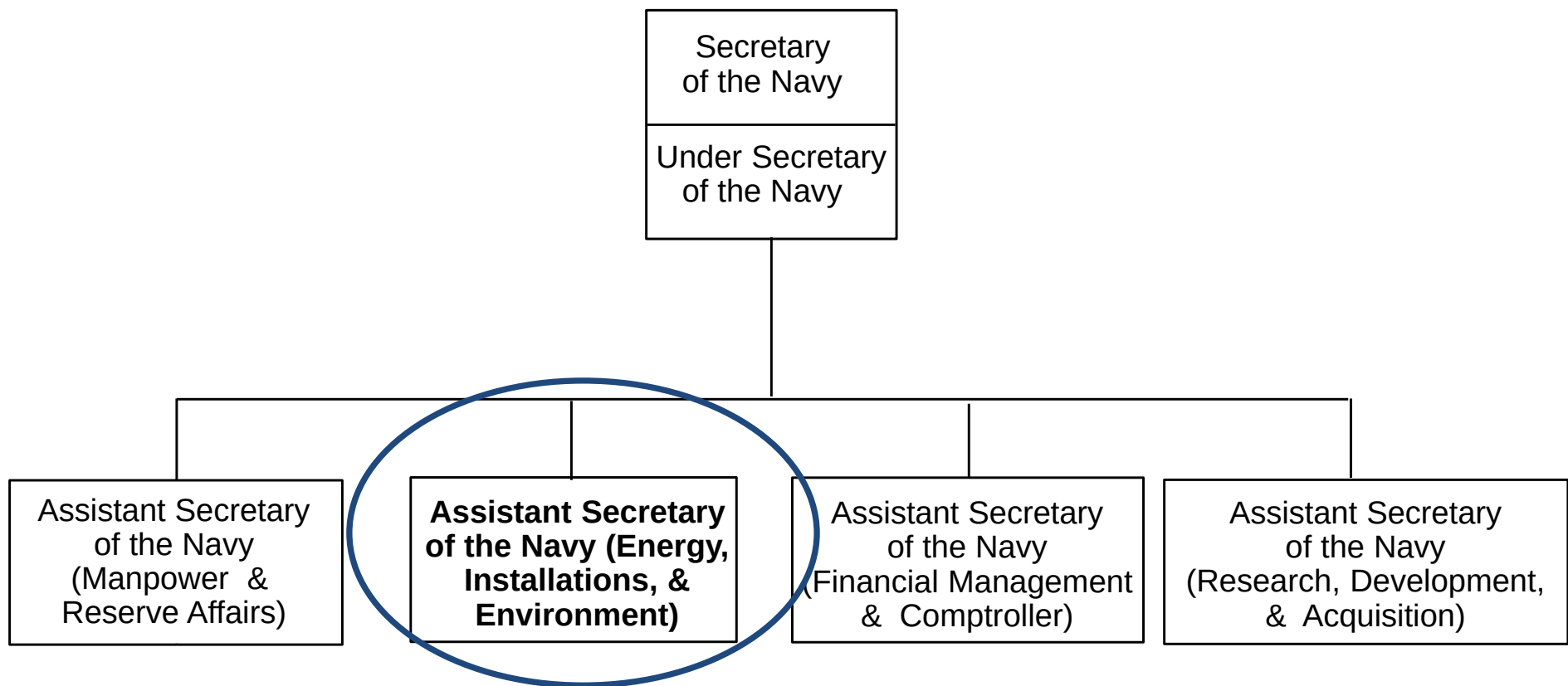


*Responsible for manpower and personnel policies, personnel readiness, quality of life and healthcare programs, and issues affecting Active Duty, Reserves, and DoN civilians*





# SECNAV Principal Advisors (cont.)

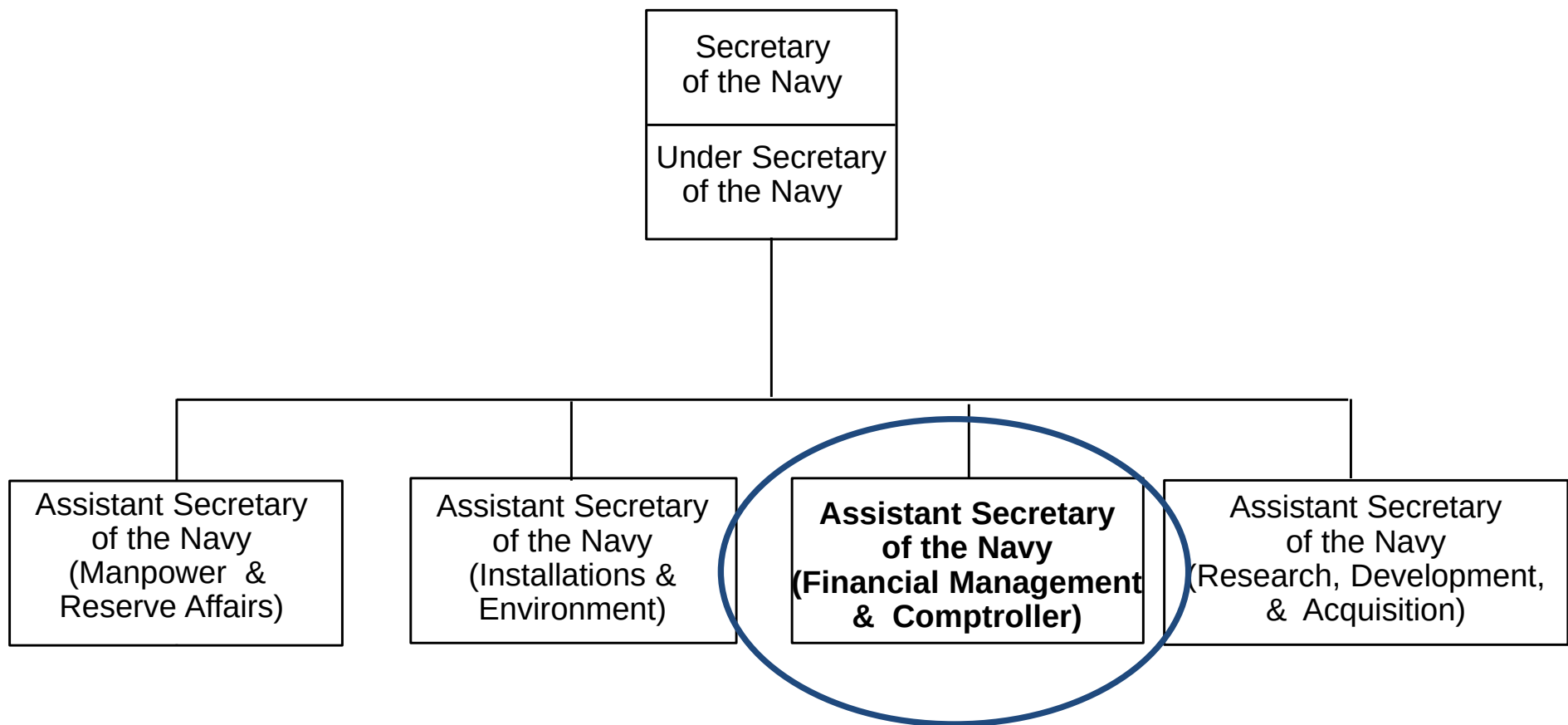


*Formulates Department-wide policies and procedures for Navy and Marine Corps energy; infrastructure sustainment, restoration and modernization; military construction; acquisition, utilization and disposal of real property and facilities; environmental protection, planning, restoration and natural resources conservation; and safety and occupational health*





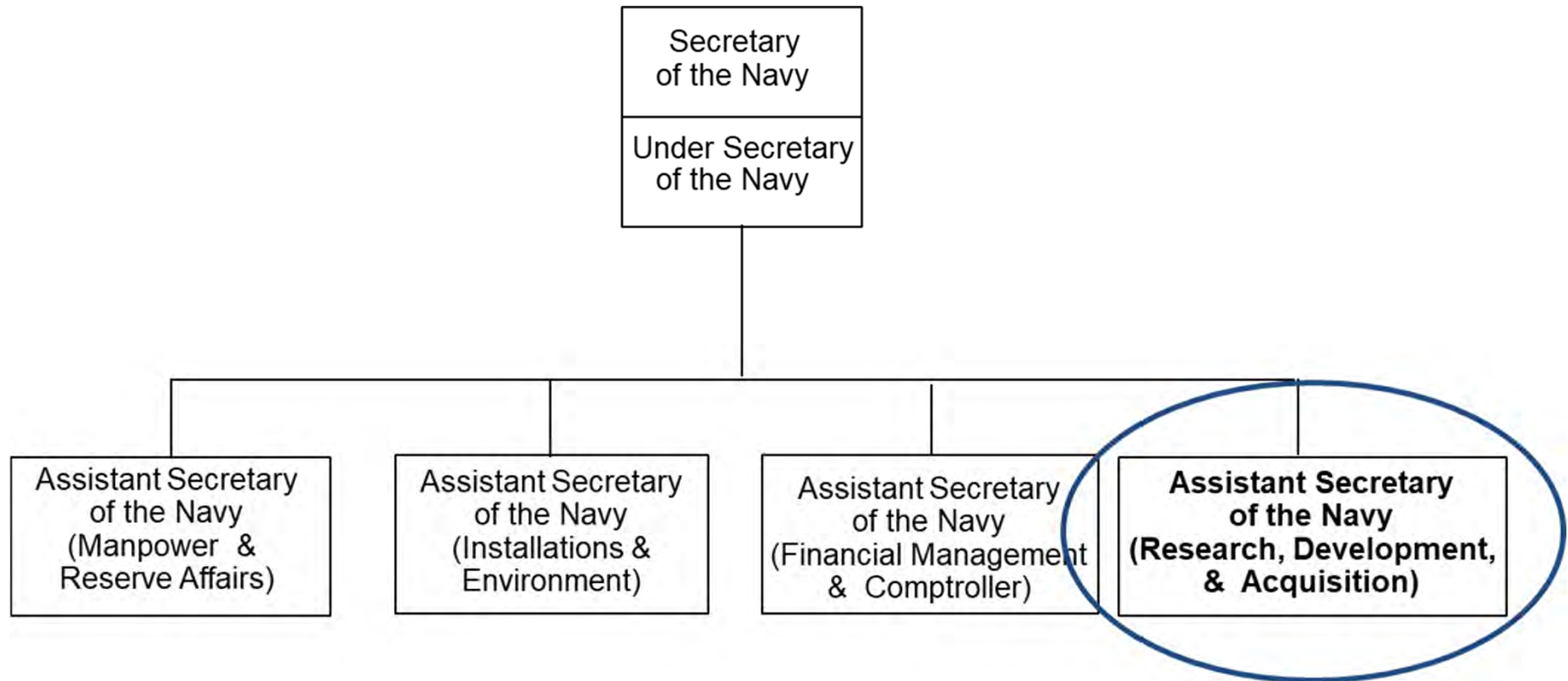
# SECNAV Principal Advisors (cont.)



*Financial Management: SECNAV's principal financial advisor*  
*Comptroller: Execution of Navy's budget*



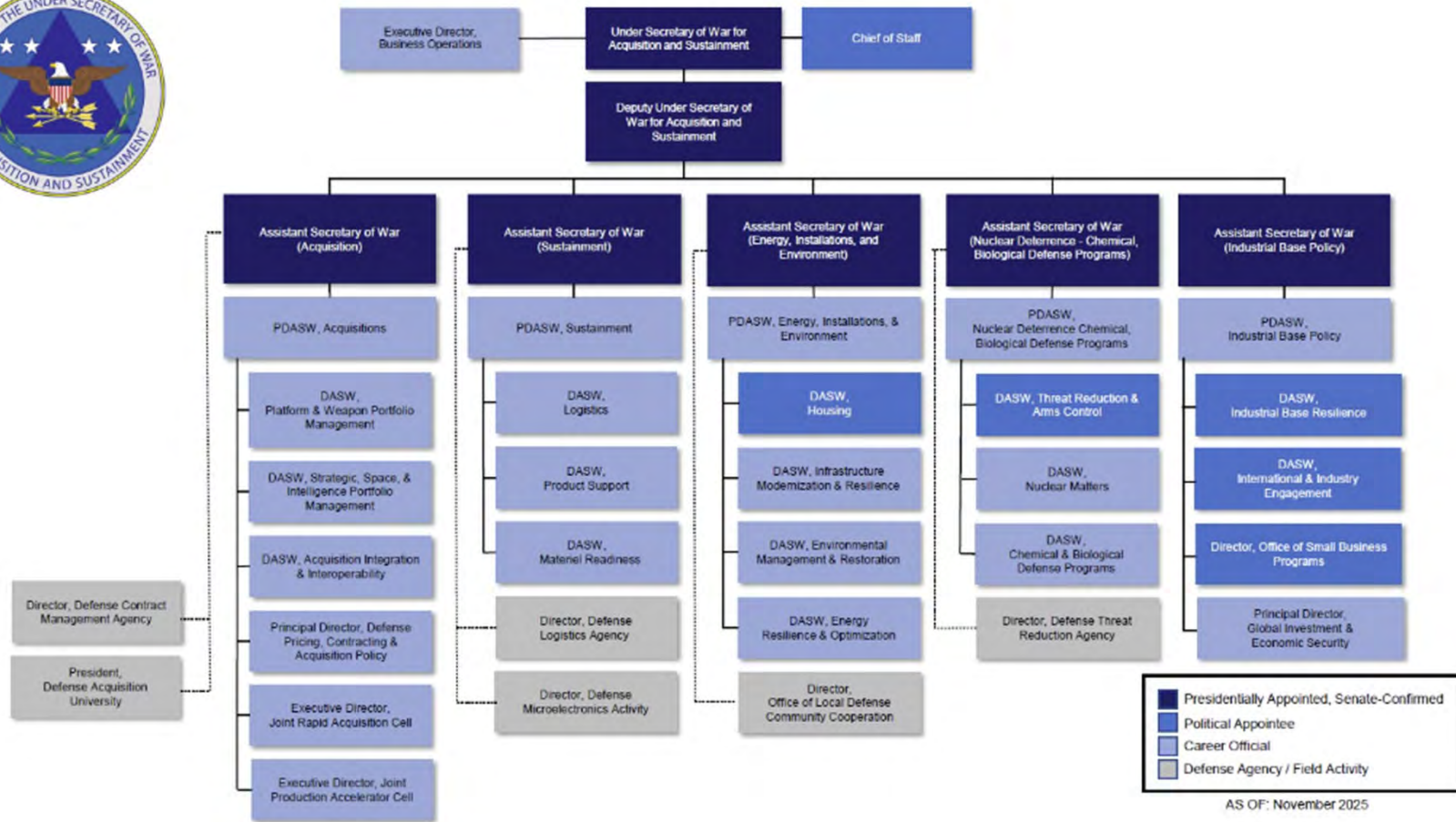
# SECNAV Principal Advisors (cont.)



*The ASN (RD&A) is the Navy's Component Acquisition Executive (CAE).  
Responsible for all acquisition policy and procedures*



# DoW Acquisition Organization



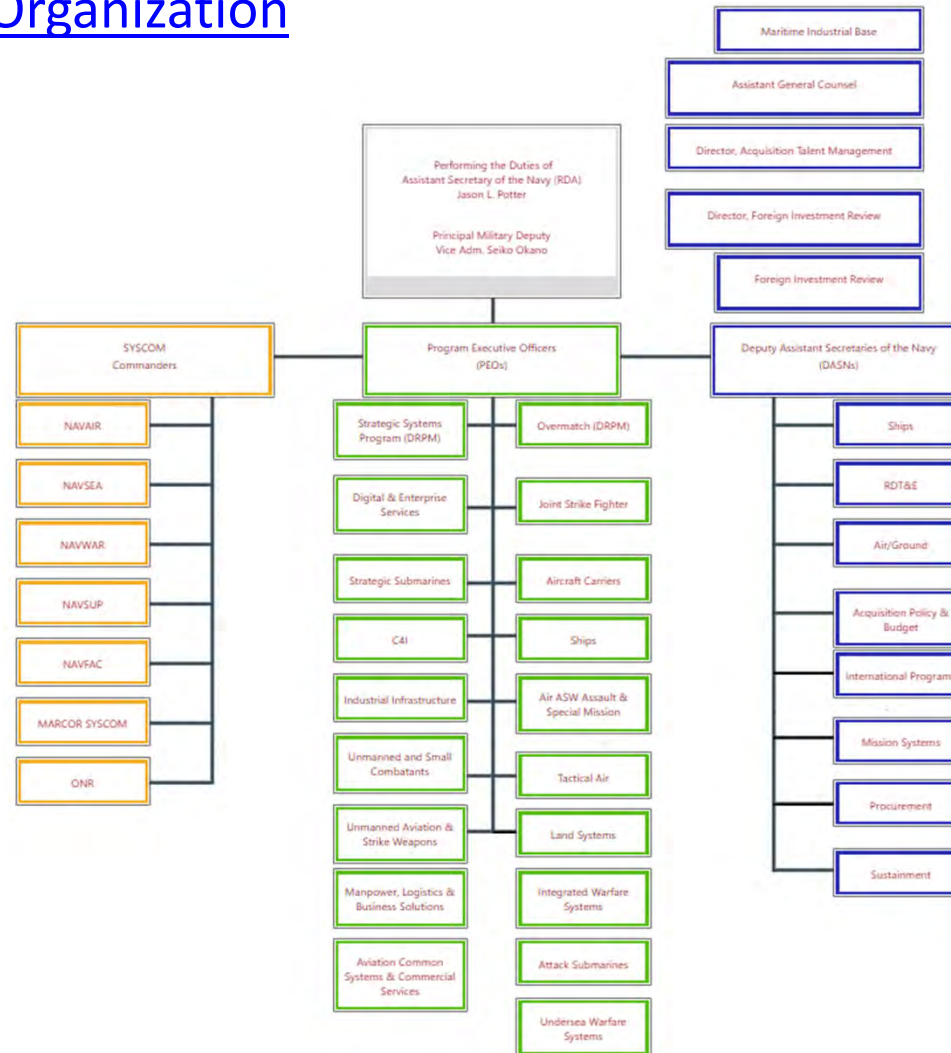
Mission: Enable the Delivery and Sustainment of Secure, Resilient, and Preeminent Capabilities to the Warfighter and International Partners Quickly and Cost Effectively

- [Acquisition and Sustainment, Office of the Under Secretary of War](#)



# Navy Acquisition Organization

- Navy Acquisition Organization





# Navy Acquisition Organization (cont.)

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- The Assistant Secretary of the Navy for Research, Development and Acquisition (ASN(RD&A))
  - serves as the Navy Acquisition Executive
  - has authority, responsibility and accountability for all acquisition functions and programs, and for enforcement of Under Secretary of Defense for Acquisition and Sustainment (USD(A&S)) procedures
  - represents the DoN to USD(A&S) and to Congress on all matters relating to acquisition policy and programs
  - establishes policies and procedures and manages the Navy's Research, Development and Acquisition activities in accordance with DoD 5000 Series Directives
  - serves as Milestone Decision Authority on Acquisition Category (ACAT) IC programs and recommends decisions on ACAT ID programs



# Navy Acquisition Organization (cont.)

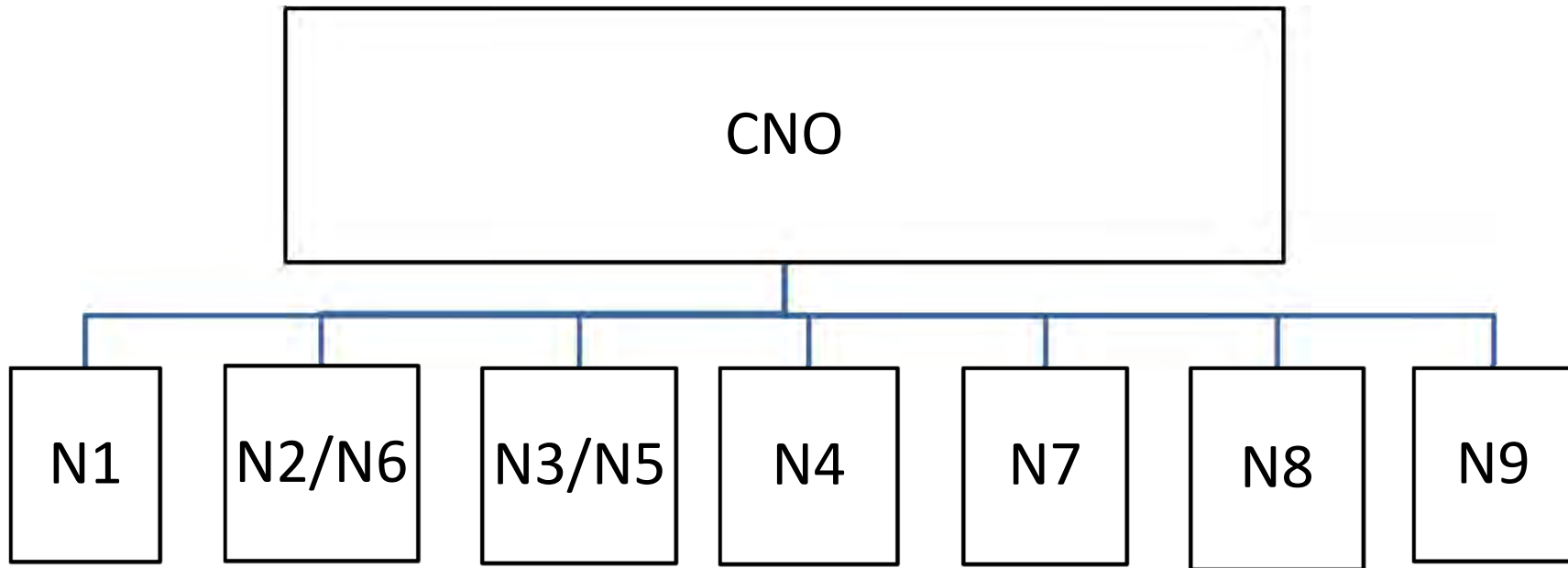
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- The ASN(RD&A) organization is responsible for the development and acquisition of Navy and Marine Corps platforms and weapon systems
- The organization consists of:
  - Staff to the Assistant Secretary
  - Program Executive Officers (PEOs)
    - e.g., PEO Carriers
  - Direct Reporting Program Managers (DRPMs)
    - e.g., Strategic Systems Program (SSP)
  - Naval Systems Commands and their field activities
- The PEOs and DRPMs are responsible for the development and acquisition of Naval systems (i.e., families of like systems (e.g., SSN))
- The Naval Systems Commands and their field activities are also responsible for systems acquisition and supporting those systems in the operating Fleet





# OPNAV Organization



Vice Admirals – Principal  
Assistants to the CNO

*OPNAV refers to CNO and staff - OPNAV is in the administrative chain of command*



# CNO Principal Assistants

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- N1: DCNO Manpower, Personnel, Training & Education
  - a.k.a. Chief of Naval Personnel
- N2/N6: DCNO Information Warfare / Director of Naval Intelligence
- N3/N5: DCNO Plans, Policy, and Operations
- N4: DCNO Installations & Logistics
- N7: DCNO Warfighting Development
- N8: DCNO Integration of Capabilities & Resources
- N9: DCNO Warfare Systems



# N1 – DCNO Manpower, Personnel, Training & Education

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- Responsible for overall manpower readiness. Formulates all personnel strategy and resource policies
  - N130 – Military Pay and Compensation and Policy
  - N133 – Nuclear Propulsion Program Management
  - N17 – Navy Culture and Force Resilience Office



# N2/N6 – DCNO Information Warfare

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- Resource sponsor for National Intelligence programs, cyber warfare, command & control, electronic warfare, oceanography, meteorology
  - N2/N6B - Assistant DCNO
  - N2/N6C - Corporate Director, IWC
  - N2/N6D - Director, Digital Warfare Office
  - N2/N6E - Director, Oceanography & Navigation
  - N2/N6I - Deputy Director, Naval Intelligence
  - N2/N6F - Director, Warfare Integration
  - N2/N6G - Director, Cybersecurity and CIO



# N3/N5 – DCNO Ops, Plans, and Strategy

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- Principal advisor on joint operations and the development of Joint strategies, plans, programs, and policies
  - N31 – Ops & Plans
  - N50 – Strategy
  - N51 – Policy
  - N52 – International Engagement
  - N53 – Asia-Pacific Advisory Group



# N4 – DCNO Readiness and Logistics

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- Logistic support requirements & resourcing for ordnance, supply, energy, distribution, Military Sealift Command (MSC), combat logistics, tug, rescue & salvage
  - N40 – Programming & Resources
  - N41 – Logistics Programs
  - N42 – Strategic Mobility and Combat Logistics
  - N45 – Energy & Environmental Readiness
  - N46 – Shore Readiness





# N7 – DCNO Warfighting Development

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- Enable the CNO to develop and ensure the Navy's warfighting advantage in order to deter, dissuade and deny, or defeat adversaries
  - N71 – Warfighting Development
    - Naval education enterprise
  - N72 – Warfare Development
    - Navy strategy and concepts
  - N73 – Strategic Warfighting Integration Cell
    - Focus on solutions for hi-pri operational problems
  - N74 – Warfighting Integration
    - Planning, concepts and campaign design & implementation



# N8 – DCNO Integration of Resources and Capabilities

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- Coordinates Navy capability study analyses & assessments. Allocates and integrates resources and requirements in the PPBE process
  - N80 – Director of Programming
    - Directs programming phase of Navy Planning, Programming, Budgeting and Execution Process (PPBE)
  - N81 – Director, Assessments
    - Lead for assessing warfighting capability, capacity, and wholeness
  - N82 – Director, Fiscal Management
    - Delegated responsibility for budget preparation and execution
  - N83 – Director, Fleet Readiness
    - Develop/provide maintenance requirements to platform resource sponsors



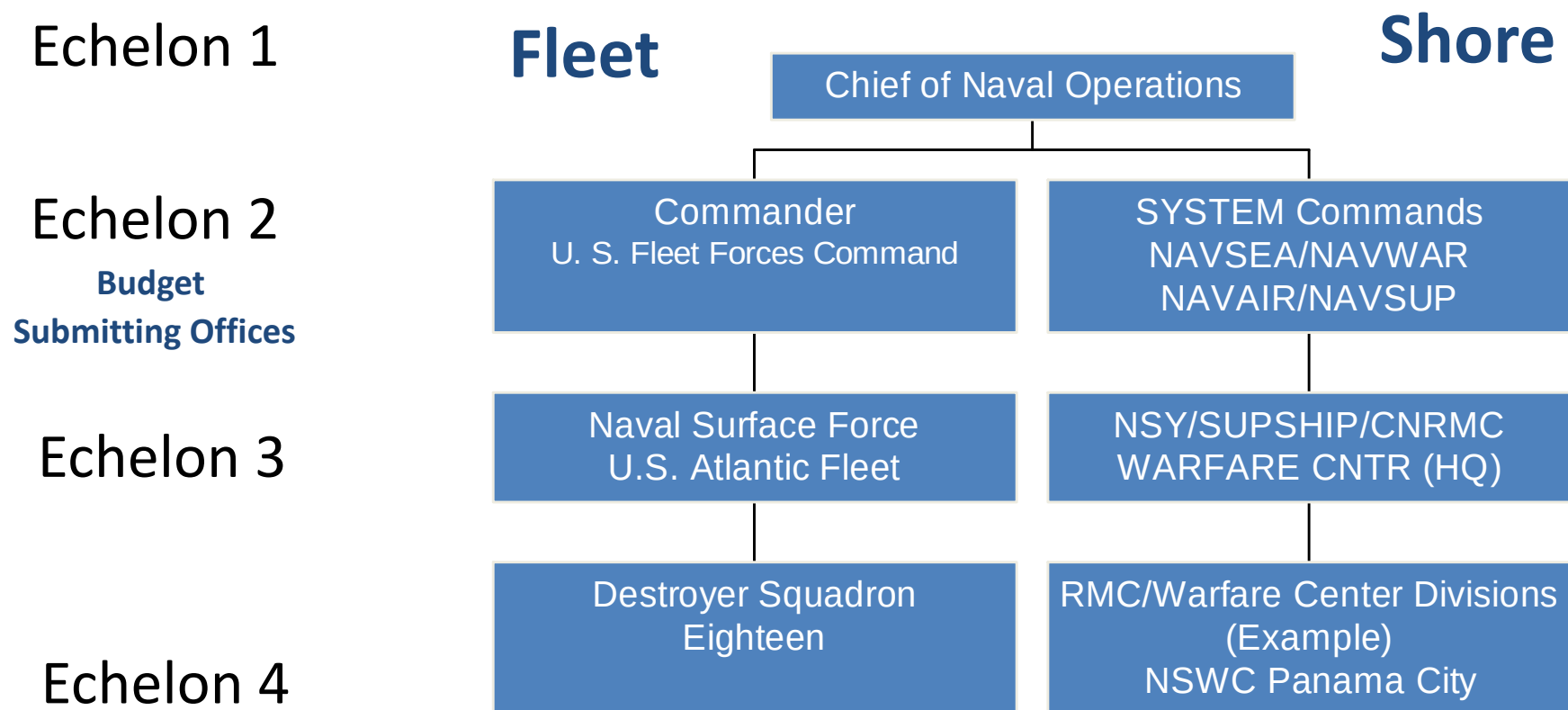
# N9 – DCNO Warfare Systems

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- Determines, validates, and integrates requirements and resources for manpower, training, sustainment, safety, modernization and procurement
  - N9B – Assistant DCNO
  - N9I – Director, Warfare Integration
  - N94/ONR – Director, Innovation, Tech Requirements/T&E
  - N95 – Director, Expeditionary Warfare
  - N96 – Director, Surface Warfare
  - N97 – Director, Undersea Warfare
  - N98 – Director, Air Warfare
  - N9SP – Director, Special Programs



# Sample Navy Organization Chart



The Navy is organized by **echelons** (tiers). CNO is Echelon One. Commands reporting directly to the CNO are Echelon Two. Commands reporting directly to Echelon Two commands are Echelon Three commands, etc.



# U.S. Fleet Forces Command

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- Functions to support the Commander's administrative control and Title 10, U.S. Code roles, responsibilities, and missions. Two functional areas include Prepare the Force and Provide the Force
- Prepare the Force
  - Man, train, equip, organize, and maintain the readiness of U.S. Navy forces
    - Navy Readiness. Generate USN forces ready to execute service missions in support of Chief of Naval Operations (CNO) and operational missions assigned by Combatant Commanders (CCDRs) in response to force requirements
      - Includes execution of Optimized Fleet Response Plan (OFRP)
    - Navy Warfighting Capability Requirements. Articulate integrated, authoritative fleet warfighting, readiness and personnel capability requirements, coordinated with other USN Component Commanders (NCCs), to CNO and develop transformational concepts for maritime operations



# U.S. Fleet Forces Command (cont.)

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- Provide the Force
  - COMUSFLTFORCOM must provide ready forces to deploy and operate forward, in response to operational requirements
    - Serve as USN global force manager. Navy Global Force Management (GFM)
    - Executive Agent (EA) for Antiterrorism (AT) and Force Protection (FP)
    - Serve as primary commander in the event of a nuclear reactor or radiological accident associated with the naval nuclear propulsion program within the AORs
    - Serve as EA for damage control modernization and improvement
    - Maintenance and Modernization Resourcing
      - In conjunction with COMPACFLT, and with support from NAVSEASYSKOM, serve as the lead for collection of resource requirements, act as lead for collection and consolidation of requirements and act as the single fleet voice and point of submission of resource requirements to CNO





# Type Commanders (TYCOMs)

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- Work for U.S. Fleet Forces Command
- Supervise specific categories of forces and activities
  - Balance requirements and resources to meet mission capabilities
    - Manning
    - Training
    - Equipment
- Provide ready forces to the operational commander for tasking at the lowest possible cost
- Normally control a ship during its unit-level training cycle
  - After the ship completes training work ups, a ship “in chops” to the operational chain of command for deployment
  - For example, a ship is ADCON to SURFOR, OPCON to 7th Fleet
- TYCOMs are in the administrative chain of command



# Type Commanders (TYCOMs) (cont.)

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- Naval Air Forces, Atlantic/Pacific
- Naval Surface Forces, Atlantic/Pacific
- Navy Submarine Forces, Atlantic/Pacific
- Navy Expeditionary Combat Command
- Navy Information Warfare Forces
- Military Sealift Command
- Naval Meteorology and Oceanography Command
- Naval Special Warfare Command



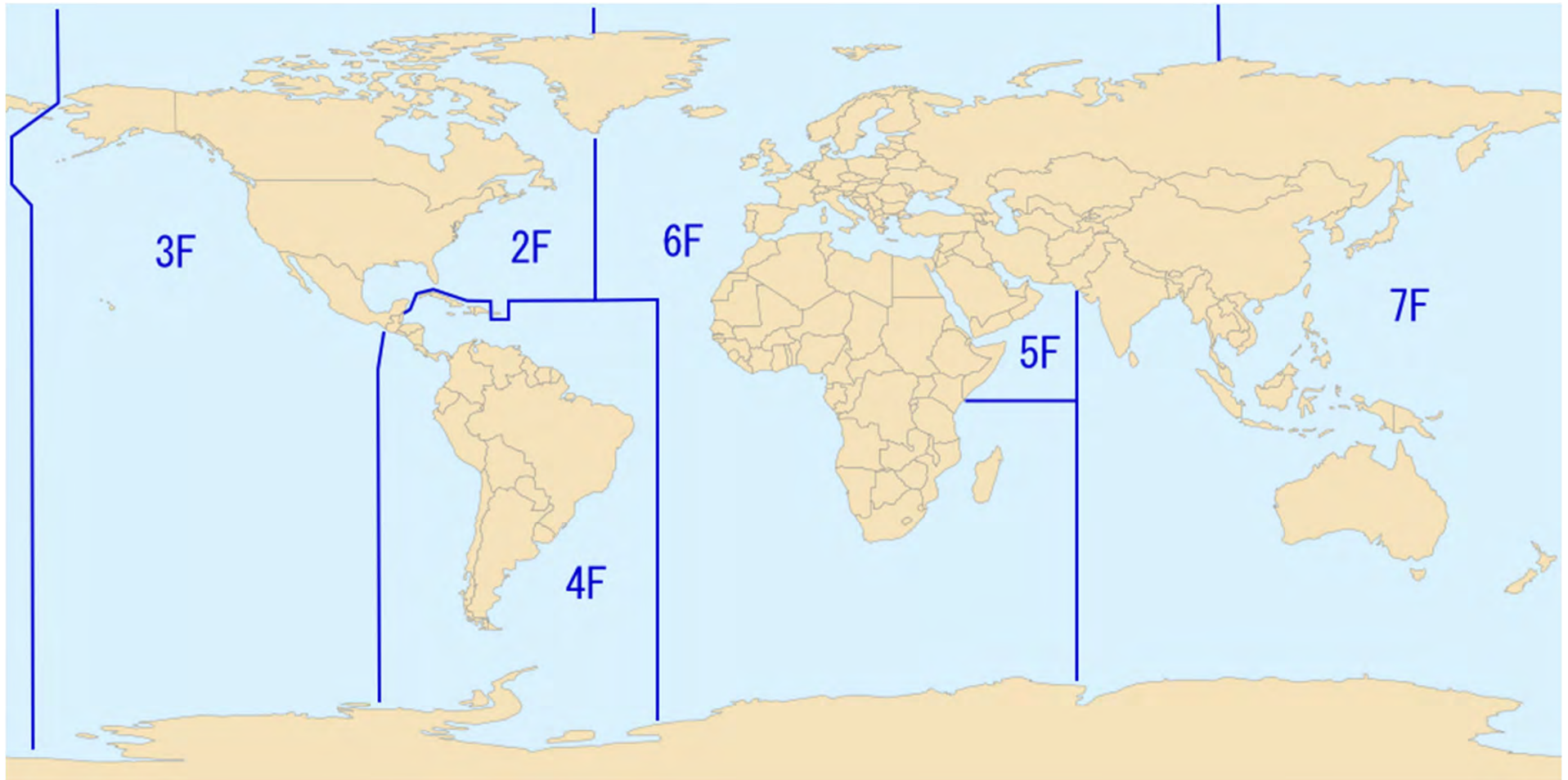
# Numbered Fleet Commanders

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- Provide naval forces and report to the appropriate Unified Combatant Commanders
- As Navy units enter the area of responsibility, they are operationally assigned to the appropriate numbered fleet
  - 2<sup>nd</sup>, 3<sup>rd</sup>, and 4<sup>th</sup> Fleet are home-ported in U.S.
    - Dual roles of force training and operations
  - 5<sup>th</sup>, 6<sup>th</sup>, and 7<sup>th</sup> Fleet are home-ported at forward locations, with forces operating in areas of responsibility
  - 10<sup>th</sup> Fleet operates in cyberspace



# Numbered Fleets





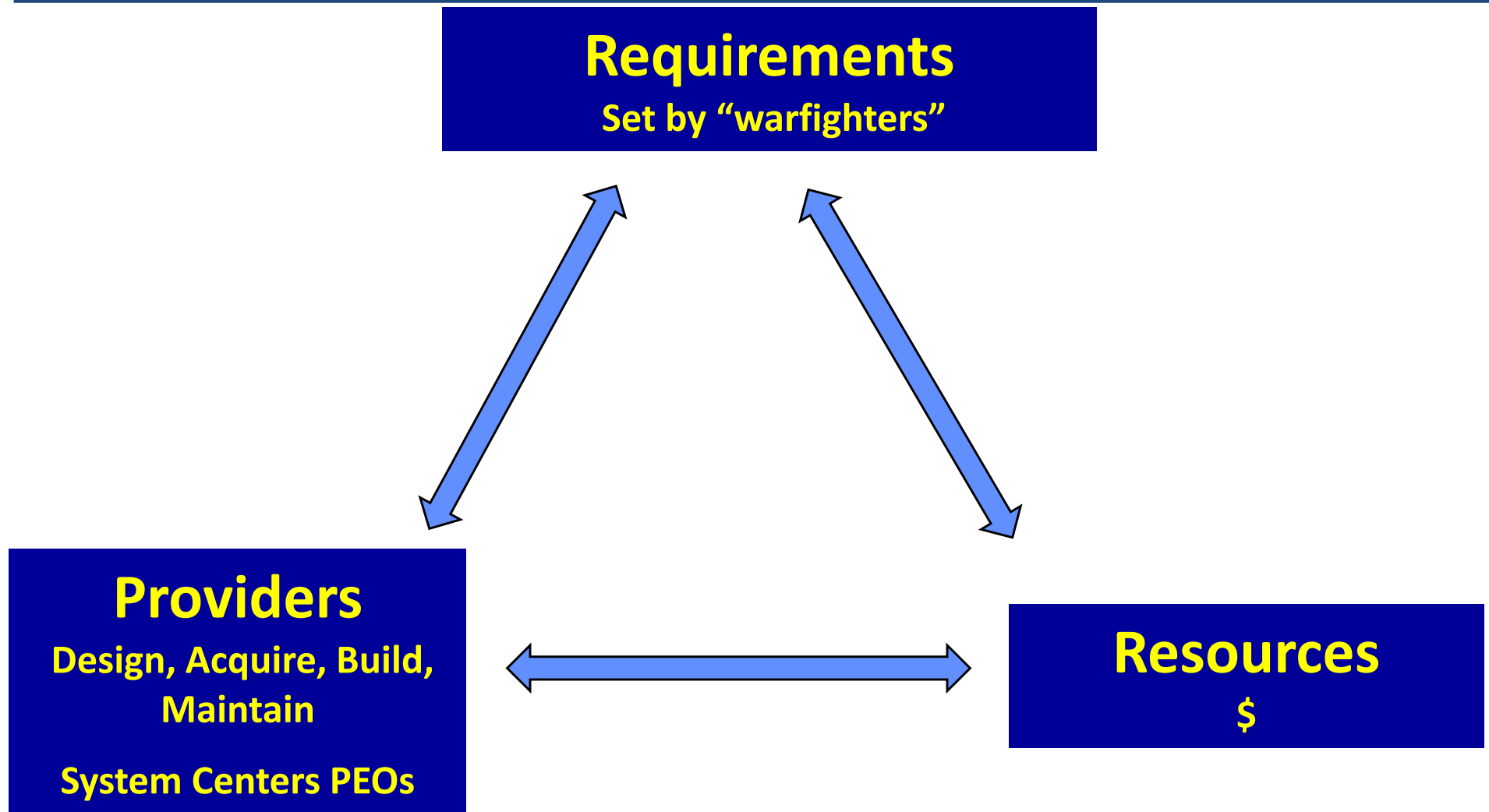
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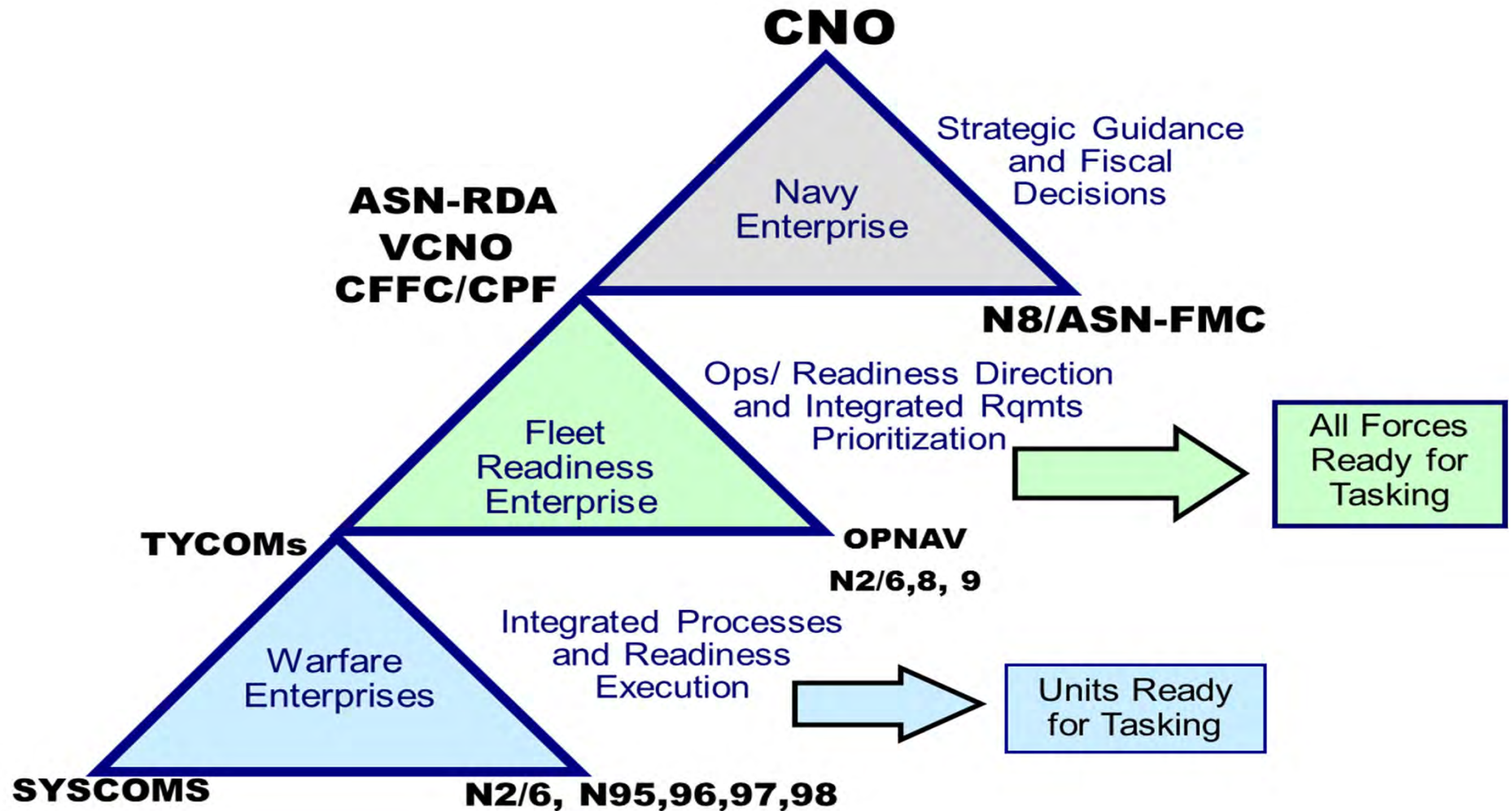
# Navy Business Model







# Enterprise Construct





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# Your ED Flag Officers



Vice Admiral Wolfe  
Director, SSP



Vice Admiral Downey  
Commander, NAVSEA



Vice Admiral Okano  
ASN RDA PMD



Rear Admiral Moton  
PEO CVN



Rear Admiral Rothenhaus  
Commander, NAVWAR



Rear Admiral Rucker  
PEO SSN



Rear Admiral Williams  
MDA DT





# Your ED Flag Officers (cont.)



Rear Admiral Brown  
SEA 04



Rear Admiral Dodson  
SEA 00R



Rear Admiral Richman  
SEA 03



Rear Admiral Wolfson  
Director, Fleet Maintenance,  
US Atlantic Fleet



Rear Admiral Ettlich  
Pacific Fleet N43



Rear Admiral Small  
SEA 05



Rear Admiral Lannamann  
CNRMC



Rear Admiral Metcalf  
PEO SHIPS



Rear Admiral Jett-Parmer  
FY26 Select - Reserve



# Summary

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- What Act defines our current command structure?
- What are the major components of the Department of War?
- What are the major components of the Department of the Navy?



# Summary

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- What are the two separate Chains of Command?
- What is the difference between the Numbered and Type Commanders?
- Which SECNAV Principal Advisor is EDO community closely aligned to?
- Which CNO Principle Advisors are EDO community closely aligned to?



# Summary

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- What do each of these terms and acronyms stand for?
  - PEO
  - DRPM
  - OPNAV
  - Echelon
  
- What are key functions of Commander U. S. Fleet Forces Command?





# Summary

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- What are the three components of the Navy Business Model?